

Vulpes vulpes

Red fox



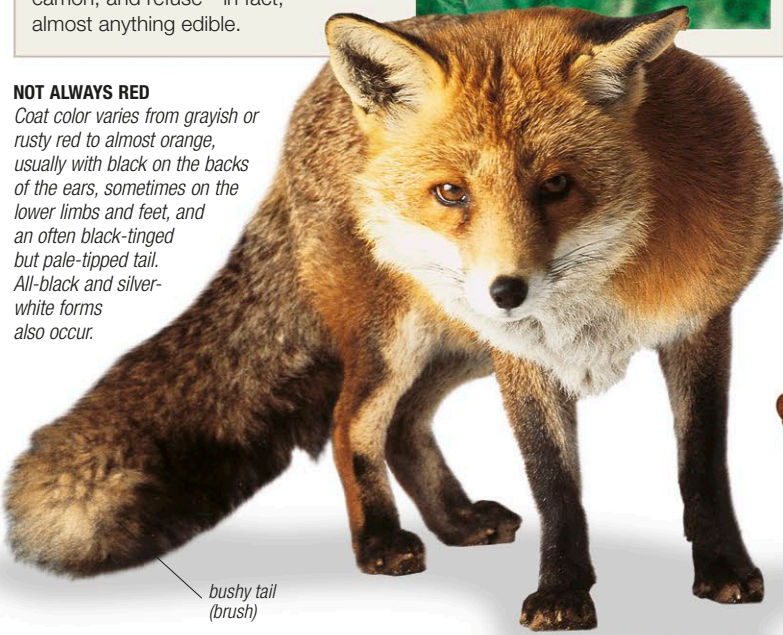
Length 23–35 in (58–90 cm)
Tail 12½–19½ in (32–49 cm)
Weight 6½–31 lb (3–14 kg)
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern



Active by day and night, the red fox is exceptionally widespread, and adaptable both in habitat, from Arctic tundra to city center, and in diet. Home is an earth (den) in a sheltered place—for example, an enlarged rabbit burrow, a crevice among rocks or roots, or a space under an outbuilding. The basic social unit is a female (vixen) and male (dog), who mark their territory of 0.4–4 square miles (1–10 square km) with urine, droppings, and scent from anal and other glands. Single-male-multifemale groups also occur but only senior females breed. Mating is in late winter or early spring when females make eerie shrieks. Gestation is 49–55 days and litter size up to 12; averages vary from 4–5 in Europe to 6–8 in North America. Both parents and “helper” nonbreeding females care for the cubs and feed them after weaning at 6–12 weeks.

THE UNFUSSY FOX

In grassy or farmed areas, a large part of the red fox’s diet comprises mainly rabbits and hares. The fox stealthily stalks its prey, then makes a dash to catch the victim before it reaches its burrow (rabbit) or accelerates away (hare). The prey is carried by the neck to a secluded spot where the fox can eat at leisure. The red fox also consumes beetles, worms, frogs, birds, eggs, mice, voles, fruit, carrion, and refuse—in fact, almost anything edible.



NOT ALWAYS RED

Coat color varies from grayish or rusty red to almost orange, usually with black on the backs of the ears, sometimes on the lower limbs and feet, and an often black-tinged but pale-tipped tail. All-black and silver-white forms also occur.

Vulpes cana

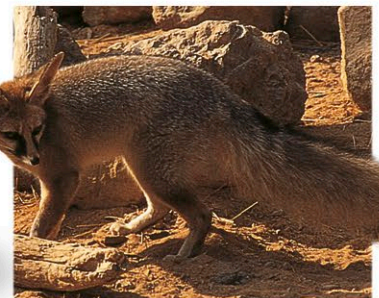
Blanford’s fox



Length 15–31½ in (38.5–80 cm)
Tail 12 in (30 cm)
Weight 2–3¼ lb (0.9–1.5 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This small fox has relatively large ears and tail, patchy body coloring in black, gray, and white, white underparts, a dark stripe along the middle of the back, and a stealthy, feline gait. It is a solitary, nocturnal hunter of small creatures, including insects, mainly in barren, rocky hills and grassy uplands. It also consumes appreciable amounts of fruit and is found near orchards and groves. Litter size is 1–3.



Vulpes macrotis

Kit fox



Length 18–21 in (45–54 cm)
Tail 8½–12½ in (22–32 cm)
Weight 3¼–6½ lb (1.5–3 kg)
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern





Similar to the swift fox (see right) in appearance and habits, this species has a more westerly range, but with overlap and perhaps interbreeding in Texas. The kit fox has longer, closer-set ears, a more angular head, and is more heavily built overall. There are 3 color forms: pale gray-brown, dark gray-brown, and intermediate gray. Its habitats vary from grassland to desert, and its diet is omnivorous. Both parents raise the 1–7 young.

Vulpes velox

Swift fox



Length 18½–21½ in (47–55 cm)
Tail 9½–13 in (25–34 cm)
Weight 3¼–6½ lb (1.5–3 kg)
Social unit Pair
Status Least concern



Recently established as a separate species from the kit fox (see left), the swift fox has a more easterly distribution. Its coloration is similar to that of the kit fox, but it is grayer on the upperparts and buff-orange underneath. It has a bushy, black-tipped tail. Both species dig dens about 3 ft (1 m) deep, with 13 ft (4 m) of tunnels, and mate from December to January—later in northern areas. The gestation period is 51 days.



Vulpes zerda

Fennec fox



Length 13–16 in (33–40 cm)
Tail 4½–10 in (12–25 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 g)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The smallest fox, the fennec has relatively large ears and a black-tinged tail tip. Its furred soles are adapted



for walking on soft, hot sand. Mostly nocturnal, the diet of this fox ranges from fruit and seeds to eggs, termites, and lizards. Unusual among foxes, it associates in groups of up to 10, but relationships are not clear. Each member digs a den several yards into soft earth. Mating occurs in January–February and the 1–4 cubs remain in the den, protected by the female, for 2 months. They are fully mature by 11 months. Hunted for its fur, the fennec fox is also trapped as a pet.